The Great Law of Peace

The Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy

Source: The Great Law of Peace (Gayanashagowa). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> The founding constitution of the Iroquois Confederacy, uniting five (later six) nations under a “Tree of Great Peace.” Its federal structure and ideas of unity and representation are often cited as an influence on later American government.

I am Dekanawidah and with the Five Nations' Confederate Lords I plant the Tree of Great Peace. . . . Roots have spread out from the Tree of the Great Peace, one to the north, one to the east, one to the south and one to the west. The name of these roots is The Great White Roots and their nature is Peace and Strength. If any man or any nation outside the Five Nations shall obey the laws of the Great Peace . . . they shall be welcomed to take shelter beneath the Tree of the Long Leaves. We place at the top of the Tree of the Long Leaves an Eagle who is able to see afar.